Weights and Measures

By Jodi Picoult

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***Actor:*** *Narrator 2; Abe, Pastor*
Actress: *Narrator 1; Sarah, Funeral Director*

TOGETHER: The loudest sound in the world is the absence of a child.

NARRATOR 2: Sarah found herself waiting for it, the moment she opened her eyes in the morning: that satin ribbon of a giggle, or the thump of a jump off the bed—but instead all she heard was the hiss of the coffeemaker that Abe must have preset in the kitchen last night, spitting angrily as it finished its brewing.

SARAH: We have to get up. . . Abe.

ABE: Right.

NARRATOR 1: He pushed off the bed in one motion and closeted himself in the bathroom, where he ran the shower long before he stepped inside, incorrectly assuming the background noise would keep anyone outside from hearing him cry.

INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR 1: The worst day of Abe's life had not been the one you'd imagine, but the one after that, when he went to choose his daughter's coffin.

NARRATOR 2: Sarah begged him to go; said she could not sit and talk about what to do with their daughter as if she were a box of outgrown clothing that had to be stored somewhere safe and dry.

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NARRATOR 1: The funeral director was a man with a bad comb-over and kind, gray eyes, and his first question to Abe was whether he'd seen his daughter. . . afterward. Abe had --

NARRATOR 2: -- once the doctors and nurses had given up and the tubes had been removed and the crash carts pulled away, he and Sarah were given a moment to say good-bye. Sarah had run out of the hospital room, screaming. *(Abe sits down on the edge of the hospital bed and threads his fingers with his daughter's. He pulls her into his arms and sobs)*

NARRATOR 1: She weighed just the tiniest bit less than she had that morning, when he'd carried her through the double doors of the emergency room.

NARRATOR 2: Medical examiners say a person who died lost twenty-one grams of weight—the measure of a human soul.

NARRATOR 1: He realized, though, holding his daughter in his arms, that the scale was all wrong. Loss should have been measured in leagues: the linear time line he would not spend with her as she lost her first tooth,

NARRATOR 2: lost her heart over a boy,

NARRATOR 1: lost the graduation cap she tossed into a silvered sky.

SARAH: It had only been a sore throat. Her fever wasn't more than 101. That was the criteria—you weren't supposed to worry about a fever until it spiked past 102.

ABE: Children weren't supposed to die of strep throat, but then again, you did not have to look far for the shouldn'ts. All over this world there were tsunamis sweeping entire countries out to sea;

SARAH: . . . there were Eskimo women with breast milk full of mercury;

ABE: . . . there were wars being fought that had been started for the wrong reasons.

TOGETHER: All over this world impossible things were happening that never should have.

******Scene******

FUNERAL DIRECTOR: We suggest that you dress your daughter the way she would have wanted. Did she have a favorite party dress, or a pair of overalls she always wore to climb trees? A T-shirt from a favorite vacation?

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ABE: There were other questions, and decisions to be made, and finally, (beat) a coffin. [At] the far end of the room three stunted coffins were propped like brave soldiers. [I] picked one painted a glossy white. (Abe keeps staring at it)

NARRATOR 1: It did not seem large enough to hold a girl as full of life as his daughter. It was certainly not large enough to pack inside the turtle shell of grief that he'd armored himself in this past day.

ABE: Which meant, of course, that even after [she] was gone, the sorrow would remain behind.

*****Scene*****

NARRATOR 1: The funeral was held at a church neither Abe nor Sarah attended, a service arranged by Sarah's mother, who in spite of this still managed to believe in God.

PASTOR: *(at the pulpit)* Try to remember, as we celebrate her short and glorious life, that sadness comes out of love. Sadness is a kind of terrible privilege. Oh, Lord, receive this child of Yours into the arms of Your mercy and into the company of angels.

NARRATOR 2: Ten minutes later, it was over. [Sarah] remained stone still while everyone left.

SARAH: *(she walks to the open coffin and forces herself to look at her daughter, she speaks softly)* Hey, baby. *(she pulls a book out of her purse and begins to read)* In a great green room . . . there was a fireplace, and a red balloon, and a picture of . . . *(she hesitates)*

NARRATOR 2: This was the part where her daughter would have chimed in: the cow jumping over the moon. But now, Sarah had to say the words for her.

SARAH: The cow jumping over the moon.

NARRATOR 2: She read through to the end, going by heart when the tears came so furiously that she could not see the words on the page.

SARAH: *(whispering)* Goodnight stars. Goodnight air. Goodnight noises everywhere. *(she takes a ragged breath and touches her finger to her daughter's lips)* Sleep tight. *(long beat)*

*****Scene*****

NARRATOR 2: A week after their daughter's death, Sarah could not stop thinking about her. She would pick up a newspaper and feel instead the rubbery band of small socks between

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her fingers as she folded them over after doing the wash. She'd be in one room and hear the music of her daughter's voice, the way grammar leaped through her sentences like a frog.

NARRATOR 1: Abe, on the other hand, was starting to lose her. He would close his eyes and try to conjure up his daughter's face, and he still could, but it was unraveled at the edges a little more each day. He found himself spending hours in her bedroom, inhaling the smell of her strawberry-mango shampoo still trapped in the fibers of the pillowcase, or poring through the books on her shelves and trying to see them through her eyes.

*******Scene*******

NARRATOR 2: [So it was not surprising when Sarah] showed up at the church, shuddering as she remembered the hymns that had been played at her daughter's funeral, steeling herself for the absence of the coffin at the altar. *(Sarah knocks on the pastor's door and as he opens it . . .)*

SARAH: Can I ask you something? Why her? . . . I get the whole God thing. But there are millions of seven-year-olds out there. Why did God take mine?

PASTOR: *(hesitating)* God didn't take your daughter, Sarah. Illness did.

SARAH: *(snorting)* Sure. Pass the buck when it's convenient.

PASTOR: Heaven's an amazing place. *(softly)* She's up there, and she's looking down on us, right now, you know.

SARAH: My daughter can't ride a ski lift without hyperventilating. She panics in elevators. She doesn't even like bunk beds. She's terrified of heights.

PASTOR: Not anymore.

SARAH: *(exploding)* How do you know that? How do you know that there's anything afterward? How do you know it doesn't just. . . end.

PASTOR: I don't know. But I can hope. And I truly believe that your daughter is in heaven, and even if she does still get scared, Jesus will be there to keep her safe.

SARAH: She doesn't know Jesus. She knows me.

*******Scene*******

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(Sarah is in her daughter's room, packing away books into boxes – she is all business)

NARRATOR 2: Sarah and Abe did not really speak to each other, not until . . .

ABE: *(Enters and sees what Sarah is doing; he is stricken)* What are you doing?

SARAH: I can't move past this knowing it's all right down the hall.

ABE: No.

SARAH: What do you mean, no?

ABE: *(taking books from the box and jamming them back on the shelf)* Just because you're ready to give her up doesn't mean I am.

SARAH: *(whispering)* Give her up? *(angrily)* Is that what you think I'm doing? For God's sake, Abe, all I want to do is function like a normal human being again.

ABE: But you're not normal. We're not normal. *(his eyes fill with tears)* She died, Sarah. *(Sarah winces; long beat)* I lost her. Please don't tell me I've lost you too.

NARRATOR 1: She thought about running her hand through his dark curls, but like most moments, it was gone before she remembered to act on it.

SARAH: *(hardening in the face of his grief – she retreats)* Maybe I need to be alone for a while. *(Sarah exits)*

NARRATOR 1: It was as if, in this new world, where the impossible had actually happened, nothing fit anymore: not language, not reason, not even the two of them.

ABE: What? *(his voice raw)* What did I do wrong? *(long silence)*

NARRATOR 1: The loudest sound in the world is the absence of a child. *(Abe sobs)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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